



RULEBOOK

3–6 players · ages 10 and up
Throne 15–20 min · The Heir's Paladin 20–25 min

PLAYTEST EDITION · V2.4

THE TALE

In the year 791 **Emperor Charlemagne** stands at the height of his power, and the court dares not ask aloud the only question that matters: which of his sons will follow him.

Four names are spoken in the corridors of Aachen: Charles the Younger, Louis the Pious, Pepin of Italy, and Pepin the Hunchback. Every great House has already chosen, and every great House keeps its choice to itself. And every knight in the kingdom knows what waits for the one who chooses right: the office of the **Heir's Paladin**, first sword of the new reign, the highest a knight may rise in the court of the Franks.

You are a knight of a House that backs one of these heirs. You send Emissaries to gather support in the **Army**, the **Church** and the **Market**. When your Emissary has completed its mission, you show your support for a House by sending a Noble there. Perhaps, though, this Noble deceives who you truly support...

When enough Nobles gather for a particular House you may **Call for the Throne** for your House's heir-apparent. It is clear:

*"To the knight whose **Status** is highest in the House that **Calls for the Throne**, they shall become the **Heir's Paladin**."*

But you are unaware of your Status in the eyes of the kingdom, although it is clear to everyone else. You know your secret allegiance, but not your worth.

*Fight, influence, capture and deceive your way to supporting the rightful heir to Charlemagne's Throne as the **Heir's Paladin**!*

The first game

THRONE

Three paths · 3–6 players · 15–20 minutes

OBJECTIVE

Put your House on the throne, and stand highest among those who did.

You are a **knight** sworn to one of the four **Houses**, and each House backs one of Charlemagne's sons. Your **House card** names the House you serve, and only you can see it.

THE PIECES



BOARD · 1

Three paths of six spaces, four Houses. The fourth is not used.



HOUSE CARDS · 16

4 per House. Your secret allegiance.



STATUS CARDS · 9

Numbered 1–9, all unique. Yours faces away from you.



CARD STANDS · 6

One per player; holds your Status card facing away.



HONOR CARDS · 36

Numbered 1–6, one hand per player.



INTRIGUE CARDS · 18

Breach of Order ×4, all others ×2. Rescue a Noble is not used.



NOBLES · 36

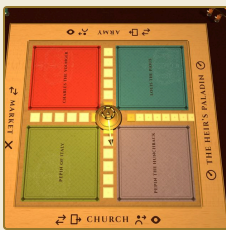
A common supply. Nobody owns them.



EMISSARIES · 12

2 per player. They walk the paths.

SETUP



The board begins empty. The fourth path is not used.

1. Shuffle the House, Status and Intrigue decks separately and place them face down beside the board.
2. Each player takes 1 **House card** (look at it; keep it hidden), 1 **Status card** placed **facing away** in a card stand without looking at it, 1 **Intrigue card**, the 6 **Honor cards** 1–6, and 2 **Emissaries**.
3. Put all 36 **Nobles** in one pile beside the board. This is the **supply**, and it is shared: a placement takes a piece of **any colour**, and a Noble removed from the board goes straight back to it. Colour carries no meaning in Throne. Only the number of Nobles standing with each House matters.
4. The undealt House cards stay as a face-down deck. It is not flipped for placements in Throne, but Army actions draw from it and search it.
5. Everyone rolls a die; the highest speaks first. Play passes clockwise.

YOUR TURN

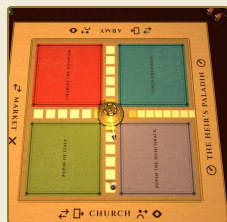
PLAY AN HONOR CARD

Play 1 Honor card face up, then move your two Emissaries a total number of **points** up to its value. **Every card is worth its number in movement and nothing else**, except the **Ace**, which moves 1 space **and** earns you an Intrigue card. When you have played all 6, take them back into hand at the end of that turn.

Skip & Reclaim: instead of playing a card you may skip your turn and take all your spent Honor cards back at once.

MOVEMENT

- Divide the points between your two Emissaries in any order.
- An Emissary on a path moves **1 space per point, always inward**, and never changes path.
- Entering play from your household costs 1 point, onto any path's **outermost space**.
- Emissaries never block one another; two may share a space.
- Unspent points are lost.

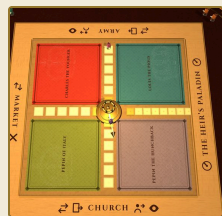


One step inward, on to the outermost space.

COMPLETING A PATH

When an Emissary reaches a path's **innermost space**, resolve in this order:

1. **Seat 1 Noble.** Take a piece of any colour from the supply and seat it **with whichever House you like**.
2. **Take that path's action** (p. 5), or **Call for the Throne** (p. 6).



The innermost space: the path is complete.

You get both. The placement never costs you the action. Return the Emissary to your household: it may set out again this turn with any points remaining. Only if the supply is completely empty do you seat no Noble, and even then you still take the action.

EXAMPLE

Alix plays a 5. Her Emissary is on space 3 of 6 on the Church; she moves it 3 spaces to the innermost space and completes the path. She seats a Noble with **Louis the Pious** because that is where she wants it, then takes a Church action and looks at her own Status. Her Emissary returns to her household.

With her last 2 points she enters her second Emissary onto the Market and moves it 1 space inward.

THE PATH ACTIONS

Completing a path grants one action from that path, or a Call in its place.
You always get an action as well as the placement.

ARMY · ALLEGIANCE *six spaces*

- **Choose your House:** look through the House deck, take the card you want, then shuffle. It leaves the deck.
- **Swap your House** with a rival: both see the new allegiance.
- **Force a new House:** a rival discards and draws blind.
- **Look at a House:** secretly learn which House a rival backs.

MARKET · NOBLES *six spaces*

- **Bribe a Noble:** move a Noble to another House.
- **Purge 2 Nobles:** remove 2 Nobles, from one House or two. They return to the supply.

CHURCH · STATUS *six spaces*

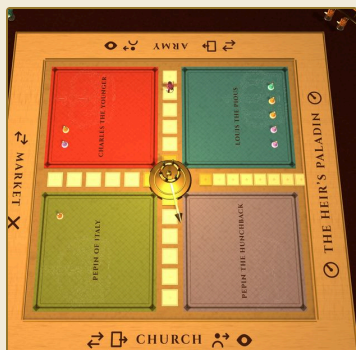
- **Swap your Status** with a rival: you get the card you could already read.
- **Draw a new Status:** discard yours and draw blind. You still will not know it.
- **Force a new Status:** a rival discards and draws.
- **Look at your own Status:** finally learn your worth.

HOW TO WIN

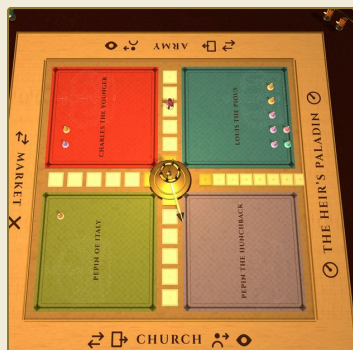
CALL FOR THE THRONE

A House reaches **quorum** at 5 seated Nobles. After completing any path you may **Call for the Throne** for a House at quorum **that you support**, instead of taking that path's action. You support exactly one House: the one on your House card.

The highest Status among the called House's supporters wins the game!



5 Nobles gather behind a House: a player completing a path may **Call** there instead of taking an action.



The **coup**. A 7th Noble is seated: a Call goes up **immediately**, no matter who seated it.

Each other player, in turn order, may answer the Call with an Intrigue. If the House falls below the quorum before the answers run out, **the Call fails**: nothing is revealed, the caller's action is spent, and play continues. If it holds, everyone reveals their House and Status cards.

Scoring is Status alone. Every player whose House card names the called House is a contender, and the highest Status among them wins, **whether or not they made the Call**. Nobles are not counted; they decided *which* House was called, not who leads it. On a tie the higher printed Status wins.

If nobody supports the called House, the throne stands empty and the game ends with no winner.

EXAMPLE · A CALL AT QUORUM

Alix completes the Church and seats her Noble with **Louis the Pious**, bringing Louis to 5. Instead of a Church action she Calls there.

Blake answers with **Defenestrate** and removes a Louis Noble. Louis now holds 4, so the Call fails: nothing is revealed, Alix's action is spent, and play continues.

EXAMPLE · A CALL AT SEVEN

Later, Blake seats a 7th Noble with Charles the Younger, so a Call happens there at once, with Blake as the caller. Alix answers with **Supplant**, but Blake answers with **Breach of Order** and cancels it.

Charles still holds 7, so everyone reveals. Alix backs Charles with Status 8; Blake backs Charles with Status 3. **Alix wins**, even though Blake made the Call.

THE SECOND GAME

THE HEIR'S PALADIN

Four paths · 3–6 players · 20–25 minutes

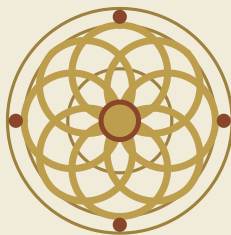
OBJECTIVE

Put your House on the throne.
Stand highest among those who did.

You are a **knight** sworn to one of the four **Houses**, and each House backs one of Charlemagne's sons. Your **House card** names the House you serve, and only you can see it.

The Heir's Paladin changes: play an Honor card, the low ones carrying a favour instead of movement, and walk your Emissaries up four paths. Reaching a centre seats a Noble **from your own reserve**, and **the deck** decides which House it joins. The fourth path turns the brass arrow to you, or forces a duel for it. At a Call, your Status is worth **+1 for every Noble of yours** behind that House.

Your Nobles are yours. Six for the whole game, in your colour, and whose Noble sits where is the heart of the scoring.



EVERYTHING NEEDED TO PLAY THE HEIR'S PALADIN IS ON PAGES
7–12.

NOTHING FROM THRONE APPLIES TO IT.

THE PIECES



BOARD · 1

Four paths, four Houses. The Paladin's path is **eight** spaces; the rest are six.



HOUSE CARDS · 16

4 per House. Your secret allegiance, and the deck that decides placements.



STATUS CARDS · 9

Numbered 1–9, all unique. Yours faces away from you.



CARD STANDS · 6

One per player; holds your Status card facing away.



HONOR CARDS · 36

Numbered 1–6, one hand per player. The low ones carry favours.



INTRIGUE CARDS · 20

Breach of Order ×4; all others ×2, Rescue a Noble included.



NOBLES · 36

6 per player, in your colour. Your reserve for the whole game.



EMISSARIES · 12

2 per player. They walk the paths.



THE BRASS ARROW · 1

Sits at the centre and marks the Heir's Paladin.

SETUP

1. Shuffle the House, Status and Intrigue decks separately and place them face down beside the board.
2. Each player takes 1 **House card** (look at it; keep it hidden), 1 **Status card** placed **facing away** in a card stand without looking at it, 1 **Intrigue card**, the 6 **Honor cards** 1–6, 2 **Emissaries**, and 6 **Nobles in their own colour** as a personal reserve.
3. The undealt House cards stay as a face-down deck. It is flipped all game to decide placements, and never runs dry.
4. Set the **brass arrow** at the centre, pointing at no one.
5. Everyone rolls a die; the highest speaks first. Play passes clockwise.

YOUR RESERVE

You have **6 Nobles for the whole game** and never gain or lose any. Every Noble you seat comes out of that six, and any removed from the board returns to *your* reserve to be seated again. A **captured** Noble is the exception: held by its captor, off the board and scoring for nobody, until a **Rescue** brings it home. If your reserve is empty you seat no Noble on a completion, but you still take the path action.

YOUR TURN

PLAY AN HONOR CARD

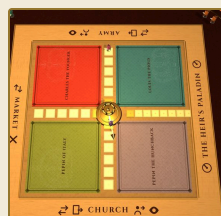
Play 1 Honor card face up, then move your two Emissaries a total number of **points** up to its value, **or** spend the card on its printed favour instead. **Never both.** When you have played all 6, take them back into hand at the end of that turn.

1	Move 1, and draw an Intrigue card. The Ace alone gives both.
2	Move 2, or Capture : take a rival's Noble off the board and hold them hostage.
3	Move 3, or Exile : move a Noble to another House.
4	Move 4, or Rescue : return one of your own captive Nobles. Its captor receives an Intrigue card or advances an Emissary two spaces.
5–6	Movement only.

Skip & Reclaim: instead of playing a card you may skip your turn and take all your spent Honor cards back at once.

MOVEMENT

- Divide the points between your two Emissaries in any order.
- An Emissary on a path moves **1 space per point**, **always inward**, and never changes path.
- Entering play from your household costs 1 point, onto any path's **outermost space**.
- Emissaries never block one another; two may share a space.
- Unspent points are lost.



The innermost space: the path is complete.

COMPLETING A PATH

1. **Army only**: choose **Command** or **Counsel** (p. 10).
2. **Seat 1 Noble from your own reserve. You do not choose where it goes.** Flip the top House card, seat the Noble with that House, then return the card and shuffle.
3. **Take that path's action** (p. 10), or **Call for the Throne** (p. 12).

Return the Emissary to your household: it may set out again this turn with any points remaining. An empty reserve seats no Noble, but still takes the action.

EXAMPLE

Alix plays a 5 and moves her Emissary 3 spaces to the centre of the Church. She flips the top House card: **Louis the Pious**, so one of her Nobles is seated there, not her choice. She then takes a Church action and looks at her own Status. With her last 2 points she enters her second Emissary and moves it 1 space in.

THE PATH ACTIONS

ARMY · ALLEGIANCE *six spaces*

On completing the Army, choose one:

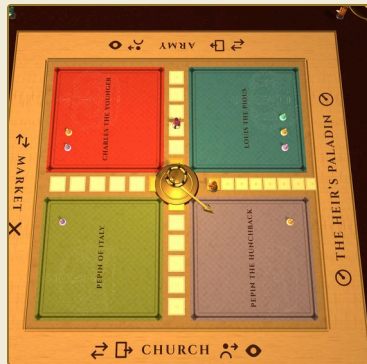
- **Command:** seat the Noble with any House you choose. You take **no** Army action.
- **Consent:** the deck decides where the Noble goes, and you take one of these:
- **Choose your House:** look through the House deck, take the card you want, then shuffle. It leaves the deck.
- **Swap your House** with a rival: both see the new allegiance.
- **Force a new House:** a rival discards and draws blind.
- **Look at a House:** secretly learn which House a rival backs.

MARKET · NOBLES *six spaces*

- **Bribe a Noble:** return a *rival's* seated Noble to their reserve, then seat one of *yours* with another House. Not available if your reserve is empty.
- **Purge 2 Nobles:** remove 2 Nobles, from one House or two. Each returns to its own owner's reserve.

CHURCH · STATUS *six spaces*

- **Swap your Status** with a rival: you get the card you could already read.
- **Draw a new Status:** discard yours and draw blind. You still will not know it.
- **Force a new Status:** a rival discards and draws.
- **Look at your own Status:** finally learn your worth.



The arrow turns.

THE HEIR'S PALADIN *eight spaces*

Seats a Noble exactly as the other paths do, with the deck deciding, and then turns the brass arrow to you, or forces a **Trial by Combat** (p. 11). It grants **no path action**, and you may never Call from it.

THE ARROW

While the arrow points at you, you are the **Heir's Paladin**: your Status counts +1, you stand among the contenders in **every** Call whichever House is named, and you take the crown on any tie.

Trial by Combat. When a player completes the Paladin's path while another already holds the arrow, the completer becomes the **Challenger**. Both secretly choose one unspent Honor card and reveal at once. The higher card takes or retains the arrow, and the **Challenger wins ties**. Both cards are discarded without giving movement or using their printed favours. A duellist with an empty hand lays 0, and neither may recover cards mid-Trial. With no current Paladin there is no Trial; a Paladin who walks the path again simply keeps the arrow.

THE INTRIGUES

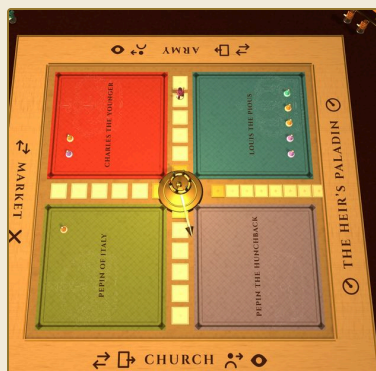
20 cards. Kept hidden in hand. You hold one at the start and draw another whenever you play an Ace. No hand limit.

ON MARCH ×2	Choose your movement, 1–6. <i>Play instead of an Honor card.</i>
HIDDEN ARCHIVE ×2	Search the Intrigue discards and take one. <i>Play on your turn.</i>
RESCUE A NOBLE ×2	Return one of your own captive Nobles. Its captor receives an Intrigue card or advances an Emissary two spaces. <i>Play on your turn.</i>
EYE OF THE JESTER ×2	Look at your own Status. <i>Play anytime.</i>
SUPPLANT ×2	Return a rival's seated Noble to its owner's reserve, then seat one of yours with a different House. Not available if your reserve is empty. <i>Play anytime.</i>
DEFENESTRATE ×2	Remove a Noble from the board; it returns to its owner's reserve. <i>Play anytime.</i>
OATH OF FIDELITY ×2	Seat a Noble with a House. <i>Play anytime.</i>
PLAGUE ×2	The completing player seats no Noble. The rest of the completion still happens. <i>Play at anyone's completion.</i>
BREACH OF ORDER ×4	Cancel the Intrigue just played, including another Breach , in which case the first card resolves after all. Removed from the game once used. <i>Play in response to any Intrigue.</i>

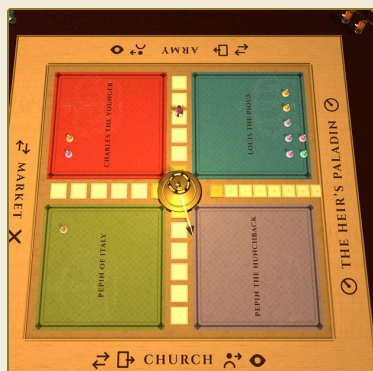
HOW TO WIN

CALL FOR THE THRONE

A House reaches **quorum** at 5 seated Nobles. After completing the Army, the Market or the Church you may **Call for the Throne** for a House at quorum **in which you stand**, instead of taking that path's action. You stand with the House on your House card, and the player holding the arrow stands in **every** House, and may Call for any of them. **The Paladin's path can never make a Call.**



5 Nobles: a player completing a path may Call there instead of taking an action.



The coup. A 7th Noble: a Call goes up **immediately**, no matter who seated it.

Each other player, in turn order, may answer the Call with an Intrigue. If the House falls below the quorum before the answers run out, **the Call fails**: nothing is revealed, the caller's action is spent, and play continues. If it holds, everyone reveals.

SCORING A CALL

Each contender's score is **their Status**, **+1 if they hold the arrow**, and **+1 for every Noble of theirs** seated with the called House. Highest score wins, whether or not they made the Call. **Ties**: the Paladin wins any tie they share; otherwise the higher **printed Status** takes it, the card itself, before Nobles or the arrow are added.

If nobody stands for the called House, the throne stands empty and the game ends with no winner.

EXAMPLE · SCORING

Charles the Younger is Called with 6 Nobles. Alix backs Charles with Status 4 and has seated 3 of her own Nobles there: she scores 7. Blake backs Charles with Status 8 but has none there: he scores 8. Cai holds the arrow with Status 6 and one Noble with Charles: he stands in the Call whatever he backs, and scores $6 + 1 + 1 = 8$. Blake and Cai tie on 8, so **Cai wins, because the Paladin takes any tie he shares**.

QUESTIONS

EITHER GAME

A BREACH OF ORDER CANCELLED MY BREACH OF ORDER. WHAT HAPPENS?

The original Intrigue resolves after all. Both Breaches are removed from the game.

MY CALL WAS BROKEN. DO I STILL GET THE PATH ACTION?

No. The Call replaced it, and it is spent either way.

CAN PLAGUE BE PLAYED DURING A CALL?

No. Plague is playable only at a completion, before the Noble is seated.

CAN AN EMISSARY COMPLETE A PATH AND SET OUT AGAIN THE SAME TURN?

Yes, with any points remaining.

CAN TWO EMISSARIES SHARE A SPACE?

Yes. They never block one another, on any path.

A DECK RAN OUT.

Shuffle its discards into a new deck. If the Intrigue deck and its discards are both empty, no card is drawn.

NO ONE STANDS FOR THE CALLED HOUSE. WHO WINS?

No one. The throne stands empty and the game ends.

THRONE ONLY

WHOSE NOBLE DID I JUST TAKE FROM THE SUPPLY?

Nobody's. Colour means nothing in Throne; take whichever piece is to hand.

DO MY NOBLES ADD TO MY STATUS AT A CALL?

No. Throne scores on Status alone. Nobles decide *which* House is Called, not who leads it.

WHERE IS COMMAND?

There is none. You already choose every placement, so there is nothing to trade the action for.

THE SUPPLY IS EMPTY AND I COMPLETED A PATH.

You seat no Noble, but you still take the path action.

THE HEIR'S PALADIN ONLY

MY RESERVE IS EMPTY AND I COMPLETED A PATH.

You seat no Noble, but you still take the path action.

I HOLD THE ARROW AND COMPLETED THE PALADIN'S PATH AGAIN.

You keep it. No Trial, and it does not stack. You seated a Noble and nothing more.

CAN I CAPTURE MY OWN NOBLE?

No. Capture takes a *rival's* Noble.

DOES A CAPTURED NOBLE SCORE FOR ANYONE?

No. It is off the board entirely until a Rescue returns it to its owner's reserve.

A LONGER COURT

Either game: experienced or large tables may set the quorum before setup. Choose a number from **4 to 8**; players may Call when a House reaches that many Nobles, and the automatic Call happens when it gains **2 more**.